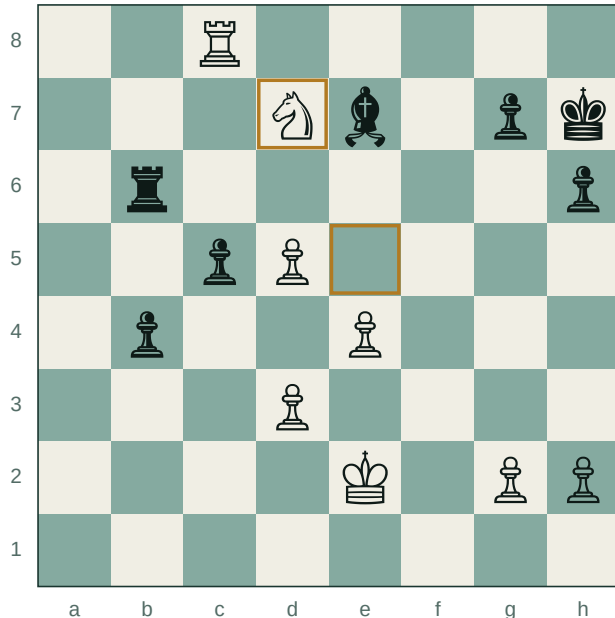


Calculated sacrifices: Black, move 39

Calculated sacrifices

Black to move



Previous move: 39.Nd7. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

39...b3 40. d6 Bxd6 41. Nxb6 b2 42. Nc4 b1=Q

39...b3 The pawn moves from b4 to b3. Recorded reply: **40.d6**.

40...Bxd6 The bishop captures the pawn on d6. Recorded reply: **41.Nxb6**.

41...b2 The pawn moves from b3 to b2. Recorded reply: **42.Nc4**.

42...b1=Q The pawn moves from b2 to b1. The pawn becomes a queen.

At the end, nominal material is White 12 / Black 15 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +4. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +4**: the balance goes from -1 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attractive attacking picture is not compensation by itself. Continue until the resulting position can be evaluated honestly.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A sacrifice exchanges material for a concrete benefit. The benefit may be mate, a stronger attack, a recovered investment, or lasting activity; it must be shown through moves.

HOW TO LOOK

State what the sacrifice changes: a defender, a line, a king square, or a critical tempo. Calculate acceptance and plausible refusal.

The defending king is on e2. Geometrically undefended: rook on c8 and knight on d7. Check for tactical protection.